

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

The Marshall Plan — Economic Aid as Cold War Strategy

US.59 — Describe the competition between the United States and the Soviet Union in arms development, economic dominance, and ideology, including the roles of the United Nations, NATO, and the Warsaw Pact.

US.63 — Analyze the causes and effects of the Second Red Scare, including Americans' attitudes toward McCarthyism, blacklisting, House Un-American Activities Committee (i.e., HUAC), and Julius and Ethel Rosenberg.

TEACHER EDITION — scoring guide and expected evidence. Not for student distribution.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Directions. Read the following two primary source excerpts and then respond to the prompt below. Analyze both documents using the SOAPS framework (Speaker, Occasion, Audience, Purpose, Significance) and construct an evidence-based argument.

The sources

Document A

Secretary of State George C. Marshall, Commencement Address at Harvard University, June 5, 1947
— U.S. government document, available through the Avalon Project, Yale Law School

“It is logical that the United States should do whatever it is able to do to assist in the return of normal economic health in the world, without which there can be no political stability and no assured peace. Our policy is directed not against any country or doctrine but against hunger, poverty, desperation, and chaos. Any government that is willing to assist in the task of recovery will find full co-operation... on the part of the United States Government. Any government which maneuvers to block the recovery of other countries cannot expect help from us.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document B

Soviet Foreign Minister Vyacheslav Molotov, Statement rejecting the Marshall Plan, Paris Conference, July 2, 1947 — diplomatic record, available through the Avalon Project, Yale Law School

“The American plan splits Europe into two groups of states and creates new difficulties in the relations between them... The Marshall plan, which envisages for American credits various conditions infringing on the sovereignty of European countries and interfering in their home affairs... will lead to nothing but a further aggravation of relations between countries.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

Using both documents and your knowledge of Cold War economic competition (US. 61, US.59), construct an argument that evaluates the Marshall Plan as a Cold War strategic instrument. Apply SOAPS analysis to both documents and

1. whether Marshall's stated humanitarian purpose was consistent with the Plan's actual geopolitical effects
2. why the Soviet Union rejected the Plan and whether that rejection was strategically rational; and
3. what the exchange between these two documents reveals about the fundamental incompatibility that defined the early Cold War

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Outside knowledge		

Scoring guide

Pts	6-point scale
6	Exemplary. Precise, arguable thesis on the humanitarian/strategic duality. Full SOAPS analysis of both documents, identifying all five elements for each with historical accuracy. Outside evidence (minimum 3 specific facts). Addresses all three prompt components. Synthesizes the documents' dialogue to reveal structural Cold War incompatibility.
5	Advanced. Clear thesis. Full SOAPS on both documents (may miss one element). Two pieces of outside evidence. Addresses two of three prompt components clearly.
4	Proficient. Arguable thesis. SOAPS partially applied to both documents (3–4 elements per document). One specific outside evidence fact. Addresses two prompt components.
3	Adequate. General thesis. Analyzes both documents but without systematic SOAPS. Some outside knowledge evident.
2	Developing. Basic claim. References at least one document, mostly summary. Minimal outside evidence.
1	Beginning. Attempts a response. May reference documents without analysis.
0	No response or off-topic.

Expected evidence and document analysis. DOCUMENT ANALYSIS EXPECTATIONS: Document A SOAPS — the universalist framing as strategic choice; the commencement setting as public communication platform; the invitation to all nations as a calculated gamble. Document B SOAPS — Molotov's 'sovereignty' argument as proxy for Soviet hegemony concerns; the Paris conference as the turning point that crystallized European division; the accusation of U.S. interference as revealing of Soviet satellite-state model. KEY EVIDENCE EXPECTED: \$13.3 billion in aid; Western European GDP recovery (1948–1952); OEEC creation; Molotov Plan and COMECON; Czech coup (February 1948) occurring simultaneously; Berlin Blockade (June 1948) as Soviet counter-pressure.

Sourcing. Every document above carries its own citation as written in the item record. Verify each against the holding institution before classroom use — an unsourced primary source is worse than a missing one.

History Hack · TroopToTeacher Technologies. Tennessee Academic Standards 2027-28. classroom-formative · pre-field-test — this activity has not been field-tested and its scoring guide is not calibrated.